Chapter 27

It's Always Possible:
A Record Forever

INHERITED FROM HER COLLEGE ERA AND TENNIS-PLAYING DAYS, QUALITIES such as anticipation of events and preparation to face them became Kiran's second nature. She had all along preserved her work notes, especially those related to her stint at Tihar Jail, with meticulous care. In fact, her home library contains a systematic documentation of records, which have been accumulated with great patience and diligence. She acquired this habit from her father, who would keep a regular record of her tennis clippings so that she could see them on her return after playing matches all over the country.

After Tihar, Kiran was back home again on study leave. Overnight, her mother converted the living room into a study, inclusive of a bed, to enable her daughter to work through odd hours. That was when Kiran found time to categorize, analyse and review all the material she had carefully preserved over the years. Interestingly, many released prisoners, both Indians and foreigners, started to call on her at her residence. They talked to her freely. Kiran has all the tape recordings, from which a new dimension emerged. Clarifications were now available. She could quiz them on issues she had not probed earlier. They too were more forthcoming since both she and they were no more 'imprisoned'. One of the freed inmates, a British national, assisted her in transcribing the recordings. Another freed inmate, a woman, drew the sketches to depict the inner scenes, as she had seen, of the state of affairs inside the prison before the changes came about. Thousands of prisoners' letters to Kiran were scanned and analysed to understand the progression of their thoughts. Besides the written documentation, Kiran had also preserved a lot of audio-visual and print material. All this she decided to put in a CD-ROM to complement the book. It was a unique experiment, but an expensive one. Her organization, which was born with the Ramon Magsaysay Award, decided to fund the CD-ROM with the main objective of spreading the prison reforms.

During this study leave Kiran travelled extensively. Within India, she visited prisons in Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Madhya Pradesh, Kerala, Tamil Nadu, Karnataka and West Bengal. Abroad, she visited prisons in Australia, Austria, Denmark, Germany, Italy, Japan, Philippines, Slovakia, Sri Lanka, the UK and the US. At all these places arrangements were made for her to interact with both the authorities and the inmates, the latter category consisting of adult men and women as well as adolescents. She could see for herself the facilities available and the programmes initiated in the prisons she had visited. She held interactive sessions with officials, floor managers and inmates. To her surprise, she came to know that the corrective programmes carried out at Tihar prison had reached them through media reports or the Internet and they were no strangers to what Kiran had to share. Just before Kiran was asked to leave Tihar, a short documentary called the 'Miracle of Tihar' had been produced. This documentary came in useful when she met prison officials.

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